



▲ Lavish burial

Norway's Oseberg ship, one of the biggest finds relating to Viking women, was the final resting place for a very wealthy woman. Her body was buried with rich grave gifts, including carts, sleds, and textiles.

Gender distinctions were expected to continue into the afterlife. The Vikings placed gender-appropriate offerings in the graves of the deceased: weapons and tools in male graves, compared with grave gifts of jewelry, needlework, weaving equipment, and household utensils for women.

Weapons have been found in a small number of female graves, but historians dispute their significance. Although Valkyries and other supernatural female warriors appear in Viking mythology, there is no historical evidence that real women took up arms. However, women are known to have accompanied Viking armies on campaign, providing domestic comforts for the warriors in camp, and they also took part in voyages of exploration. For example, spindle whorls, ring pins, and other artifacts associated with women, found in excavations of the Viking settlement at L'Anse aux Meadows in Newfoundland, confirm saga accounts of women joining the expeditions to Vinland.

Legal status

In Viking society, unmarried women fell under the authority of their fathers. Marriage itself was a contract between the father and the prospective bridegroom—the woman's

BIOGRAPHY

AUD THE DEEP-MINDED

The central character of the 13th-century *Laxdæla Saga*, Aud the Deep-Minded was the only woman among the leaders of the Viking settlement at Breiðafjörður in Iceland. As the daughter of a Viking chief living in the Scottish Hebrides, and the widow of Olaf, the king of Dublin, Aud was a woman of natural authority. However, faced with opposition from the native Gaels, her position became insecure. She commissioned a ship to be built secretly in the forest, and sailed it first to Orkney and then on to Iceland with 20 men under her command. Aud settled in Laxardale where she claimed land for her people.

